

A Proposed Model of the Role and Impact of Personality in Online Travel Information Search and Travel Purchases

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ABSTRACT

Given the increasing importance of online travel shopping and the need to better understand what motivates travellers to purchase online, this study proposes a conceptual model that relates personality, online travel information search, involvement and online travel purchases. As a conceptual paper, the study is limited to literature and prior empirical research. However, it provides a solid basis for future investigation by reviewing prior empirical research concerning the constructs proposed in the model and by supporting possible structural relationships among those constructs.

Key Words: Online consumer behaviour, involvement, online travel shopping, personality, information search

INTRODUCTION

The development of Information Communication Technologies (ICTs) and particularly the Internet has had a profound impact on the travel industry (Buhalis & Law, 2008; Kamarulzaman, 2007; Mack, Blose, & Pan, 2008; Mamaghani, 2009). These developments have changed travellers' behaviour (Buhalis & Law, 2008) that now depend on the Internet to search for information, plan their travel, and purchase online (Jeong & Choi, 2005). Different sources provide evidence that illustrate the importance of online travel shopping. For instance, in a survey led by Nielson (2008), travel was the most important online transaction category. Forty percent of Americans and 30% of Europeans book travel online and although in Asia only 20% do so, it is expected that this percentage will rise to 30% to 40% over the next few years (Leggatt, 2011). The future of online travel shopping also looks promising. In fact, PhoCusWright, one of the leading travel industry research firms, predicts that by the end of 2012 travellers will book one third of the world's travel sales online (Travel Pulse, 2011).

As the competition in ecommerce is intensified and travel shopping steadily increases, it is crucial to detect and examine which variables influence travellers to purchase online (Mark R. Brown, Muchira, & Gottlieb, 2007; Kah et al., 2008). Although many researchers have addressed the topic for more than a decade, knowledge gaps still exist. These gaps were identified through a thorough literature review, which included 55 articles from leading tourism and hospitality journals and proceedings. The review revealed that few studies (Card, Chen, & Cole, 2003; Heung, 2003; Kamarulzaman, 2007; Lee, Qu, & Kim, 2007; Li & Buhalis, 2005, 2006) had addressed online travel purchasers' personality traits and the ones that did, did not have the analysis of personal traits as their main aim. This conclusion is echoed in Leung and Law's (2010) review of personality research in the Tourism and Hospitality context, as they concluded that only two studies had related consumers' personality with their online shopping behaviour. Moreover, the role of personality, using the Big Five personality framework in online travel purchasing behaviour has never been carried out. Thus, to fill this gap, the model proposed in this study intends to explore the relationship between personality, operationalized by the five factor model, and the purchase of travel online.

The proposed model also reflects on the gap of extant literature exploring the search for travel information online on social media websites and the purchase of travel online. It is well known that social media websites are used for searching for travel information (Gretzel & Yoo, 2008; Gretzel, Yoo, & Purifoy, 2007; O'Connor, 2008; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). Nevertheless, no study has explored how the behaviour toward social media relates to online travel shopping. Furthermore, the role of personality in online travel information will also be explored, namely within social media websites.

Another interesting variable that the literature review also showed that few researchers have explored is involvement in the context of online travel shopping (e.g. [Card et al., 2003](#); [Kamarulzaman, 2007](#); [Moital, Vaughan, & Edwards, 2009](#)). Involvement is generally considered an important construct in explaining consumer behaviour ([Gainer, 1993](#)) affecting the decision process and the search for information ([Laurent & Kapferer, 1985](#)). On the other hand, Bloch and Richins (1983) proposed that personal characteristics affected involvement. Thus, it is believed that personality will also affect involvement, which in turn will influence online travel information search and the intention to purchase travel online.

LITERATURE REVIEW AND HYPOTHESES

Personal Traits and Personality

Although personal traits are important to understand individuals' online purchasing behaviour, very few studies have looked at this issue. Furthermore, the ones that do examine personal traits individually, such as innovativeness (e.g. [Card et al., 2003](#); [Heung, 2003](#)), but they do not examine the role of personality as a whole. Leung and Law's (2010) review of personality research in the Tourism and Hospitality context concluded that online personality is a relatively unexplored field. In the present study, personality will be operationalized through the five-factor model, commonly known as the Big Five, which consists of five personality traits: openness, conscientiousness, extraversion, agreeableness and neuroticism. This model is appealing as it combines many personality constructs, it is comprehensive and efficient ([McCrae & John, 1992](#)). One of the personality dimensions that has been most frequently investigated within the leisure context is extraversion and has been considered the social factor ([Barnett, 2006](#)). People who are extraverted are indeed sociable, but are also talkative, optimistic, enthusiastic, active and fun-loving ([Barnett, 2006](#)). Neuroticism has been considered an emotional stability factor. Individuals with high scores are typically depressed, angry, hostile, worrying, frustrated and self conscious ([Barnett & Klitzing, 2006](#)). Individuals that are high on Openness to Experience are imaginative, creative, curious, original and prefer variety ([Barnett & Klitzing, 2006](#)). People who are more open to new experiences tend to be innovative ([Correa, Hinsley, & Zuniga, 2010](#)). Innovativeness *is the degree to which an individual is receptive to new ideas* ([Chang, Cheung, & Lai, 2005](#), p. 533) and has been found to have a positive relationship with the adoption of online travel shopping ([Kamarulzaman, 2007](#); [Li & Buhalis, 2005, 2006](#)) and with the search for travel information online ([Kah et al., 2008](#)). Online travel purchasers like to try new technology and are more high-tech prone ([Card et al., 2003](#); [Heung, 2003](#)). Conscientiousness individuals are guided by their conscience, hard working, well-organized, and punctual and goal directed. In contrast, those who are low in conscientiousness are impulsive and easygoing ([Barnett & Klitzing, 2006](#)). Individuals that are high in agreeableness, the last dimension from the five factor personality model, are altruistic, nurturing, caring, good natured and trusting ([Barnett & Klitzing, 2006](#)). These personality characteristics are likely to influence the intention to purchase travel online. Moreover, a plethora of studies have provided evidence that personality influences consumer attitudes and decisions ([Bennett, 1997](#)). Thus, it is expected that an each Internet user's personality trait will affect intention to purchase travel online.

Search for travel information online

The Internet has changed the way travellers search for information ([Arsal, Backman, & Baldwin, 2008](#)) and has become increasingly popular as a means to search for travel information ([Xiang & Gretzel, 2010](#)). Several studies (e.g. [Jensen, 2011](#); [Kamarulzaman, 2007, 2010](#); [Susskind & Stefanone, 2010](#); [Wolfe, Hsu, & Kang, 2005](#)) have provided evidence that online travel information search and online travel purchasing have a positive relationship, while others argued that they are not related ([Li & Buhalis, 2005, 2006](#); [Powley et al., 2004](#)). The evolution of the social Internet is changing how people search and purchase travel ([PhoCusWright, 2011](#)). In fact, the importance of social media websites in searching for travel information has been stressed in several studies ([Gretzel & Yoo, 2008](#); [Gretzel et al., 2007](#); [O'Connor, 2008](#); [Xiang & Gretzel, 2010](#)). For example the World Travel Market Industry Report (2010) revealed that 36% of travellers from the United Kingdom used social media before booking a holiday. However, no study has associated travel information search on social media websites with intentions to purchase travel online. In the proposed model, search for travel information online will be divided into search for travel information on social media websites and search for travel information online on other travel websites. For the purpose of this study, social media websites are electronic communications through which users create online communities to share information, ideas, personal messages, and other content (as videos), such as Tripadvisor and travel blogs. Online travel information search, excluding social media websites, includes other websites, such as Destination Management Organizations websites, travel agencies and travel portals. Based on the above arguments it is expected that Internet users' intention to purchase travel online will be positively influence by online travel information search.

Consumer characteristics, along with other factors such as culture, demographic variables and product characteristics, influence traveller's information search behaviour (Gursoy & Umbreit, 2004). Additionally, Correa, Hinsley and Zuniga (2010) found that people who were more extraverted, open to new experiences and with high levels of neuroticism used social media more frequently. Thus, it is expected that Internet users' personality, based on the five factors model, will also influence Internet users' information search behaviour. Particularly, it can affect the type of websites (social media or non social media) that they search for travel information on. Thus, this research suggests that each Internet user's personality trait will affect their search for travel information online.

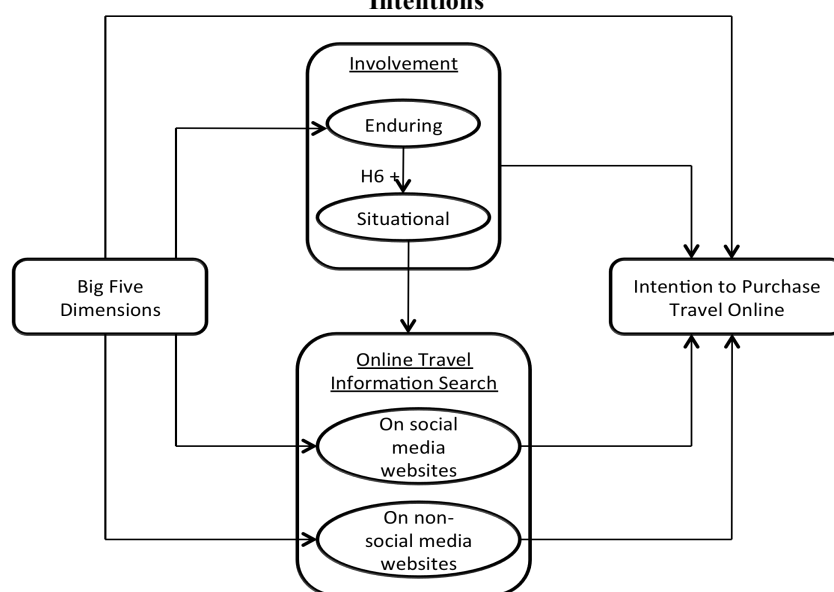
Involvement

Involvement is an important construct in explaining consumer behaviour (Gainer, 1993). An early definition of involvement was given by Day (1970) that defines it as the general level of interest in the person/object. However, involvement varies across consumers and situations and is not inherent in products (Gainer, 1993). Consequently, researchers have distinguished enduring involvement from situational involvement. Enduring involvement is a motivational state that exists in regard to the product on a long term basis, independently of purchase situations (Dholakia, 2001; Richins & Bloch, 1986), while situational involvement is defined as an internal state, which describes consumer's interest for a specific purchase situation (Koklic & Vida, 2004, p. 269). Dholakia (2001) provided evidence that enduring involvement positively and significantly influences consumers situational involvement prior to a purchase occasion. On the other hand, Bloch and Richins (1983) proposed that personal characteristics affected involvement. On the basis of these arguments, it is expected that each Internet user's personality trait will affect their enduring involvement with travel. Moreover, Internet user's situational involvement with travel will be positively influenced by their enduring involvement with travel.

Consumers level of involvement affects their decision process and their search for information (Laurent & Kapferer, 1985). In general, highly involved consumers actively look for information from alternative sources (Assael, 1981). In the travel context, Kamarulzaman (2007) provided evidence that supported that consumers' involvement had a direct effect on the adoption of online travel shopping, and Card et al. (2003) further found that online travel purchasers have higher degrees of involvement. This is important since Moital, Vaughan, Edwards and Peres (2009) concluded that the more involved a consumer is with purchasing leisure online, the higher the intention to purchase leisure travel online. Based on these, the present study suggests that Internet users' intention to purchase travel online will be positively influenced by their involvement with travel and that their online travel information search will be positively influenced by their situational involvement with travel.

Based on the literature review, several hypotheses were formulated and are summarized in the model illustrated in figure 1.

Figure 1
A Conceptual Model of Personality, Involvement, Online Travel Information Search, and Purchase Intentions



PROPOSED METHODOLOGY FOR MODEL TESTING

Since the main aim of the model is to explore the influence of personality on the purchase of travel online, the hypotheses should be tested on a sample of Internet users, since they have already purchased travel online or exhibit a greater propensity to shop online, compared to individuals that do not use the Internet. A sample of Internet users is also considered to be more appropriate compared to taking either industry experts (e.g. Card et al., 2003), students (e.g. Anckar & Walden, 2001; Mark R. Brown, Muchira, & Gottlieb, 2005; Mark R. Brown et al., 2007; Cho & Agrusa, 2006; D. J. Kim, Kim, & Han, 2007; L. H. Kim, Kim, & Leong, 2005; L. H. Kim, Qu, & Kim, 2009; Klein, Kohne, & Oorni, 2005; Morosan & Jeong, 2006; Morosan & Jeong, 2008; Morrison, Jing, O'Leary, & Cai, 2001; Susskind & Stefanone, 2010), managers (e.g. Powley et al., 2004) or using secondary data (e.g. Beldona, Morrison, & O'Leary, 2005; Weber & Roehl, 1999).

The survey should be Web-based, as data collection through the Internet is believed to be more appropriate and suitable for studies addressing e-commerce (Chen, 2006) and has several advantages. Indeed, they can be completed when the respondent chooses to do so, a representative number of the population may be reached, and respondents find them to be appealing (Cook, Heath, & Thompson, 2000). Furthermore, as data is captured in an electronic format, there will be time and cost savings (Kaplowitz, Hadlock, & Levine, 2004).

Different measurements of the big five traits have been developed over time. The most commonly used being Goldberg's (1992) 100 item Trait Descriptive Adjectives (TDA), Costa and McCrae's (Costa & McCrae, 1992) NEO Personality Inventory, with 60 items, and John, Donahue and Kentle's (1991) 44-item Big Five Inventory (BFI). The BFI has the advantage of taking only about 5 minutes of administration time, compared with about 15 minutes of the other two measurements (John & Srivastava, 1999). Therefore, and since there are other constructs to measure, the BFI is suggested to measure Internet users' *Personality Traits*. To measure *Product Involvement*, McQuarrie and Munson's (1992) scale, based on the scale developed by Zaichowsky (1985), will be used to examine Internet user's level of interest in travel. Adapting Dholakia's (2001) two-item situational involvement scale is also suggested to measure this construct in the model. To measure online travel information search, Jensen (2011) used a three-item scale to determine the number of times respondents visited specific websites, which is adequate to measure *travel information search on non social media websites*. For online travel information search on social media websites, respondents should be asked questions such as "How often do you visit online travel communities (e.g. Tripadvisor) to search for travel information?", "How often do you visit travel blogs on the Internet to search for travel information?", "How often do you visit Facebook to search for travel information?" and "How often do you visit Youtube to search for travel information?". Finally, the variable *Purchase Intentions* should be examined by a two-item 7-point Likert type scale ranged from "7" being *very likely* to "1" being *very unlikely* that reflects Internet user's intention to purchase travel online on the next travel purchase and the probability of purchasing travel in the future.

CONCLUSIONS AND IMPLICATIONS

Several researchers have studied online travel shopping for more than a decade, yet knowledge gaps still exist. This study, focusing on those gaps, has developed a theoretical model of the impact of personality on online travel information search, involvement and intention to purchase travel online. There are several implications for both academics and tourism industry practitioners. In the academic field, this study can be a starting point for future researchers addressing the topic. Furthermore, researchers can test the model empirically. The results of empirical studies will be useful not only for academics, but also for tourism industry practitioners, to understand how personality affects Internet users' involvement, their intentions to purchase travel online and their search of travel information online. Such knowledge is paramount for the successful implementation of online marketing strategies.

The conceptual model developed also intends to examine if online travel information influences intentions to purchase online. Consistent evidence of an association is lacking due to contradictory findings in past studies. What is noteworthy of this model is that it explores the role of social media as a means of travel information search and its influence on online travel shopping. Online social networking will play a crucial role in online transactions (Kasavana, Nusair, & Teodosic, 2010). Therefore, it is important to understand Internet users' use of social media websites when searching for travel information. With this knowledge, tourism practitioners and marketers can improve online travel distribution strategies and choose which types of websites are more adequate for marketing.

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